# MODULE 7
# The Kill Decision
# Kill Your Bad Ideas Before They Kill Your Startup

ASSIGNMENT: Run a pre-mortem and define your kill criteria

A joint initiative by

## Check-In:

# What is your Energy Level Today?

## Check-In:

# How much new revenue did you sign?

## Check-In:

# The Outcome - Go, Pivot, or Kill?

# Today

Check-in — prototype reactions + the GPK question (15')

**IDEA 1 · Monkey first (10')**

**IDEA 2 · Pre-mortem: find the cause of death early (10')**

**IDEA 3 · Test the riskiest assumption, not the easiest (15')**

**IDEA 4 · Go · Pivot · Kill — on pre-committed criteria (10')**

Case · Quibi: $1.75B of unkilled assumptions (30')

Workshop · Kill Your Darlings — the tribunal (90')

# Recap from last time

# Your Presentations

# Show us where you‘re at in 3 Minutes or less!

| What did you do? | What did you learn? | How can we help? |
| --- | --- | --- |

Make it credible:

1. Facts: Statistics or Research: What do they say? What does it mean? Where are they from?
2. Numbers: Usage or Surveys: How were they reported? How did they change? Why is it relevant?
3. Quotes: Interviews or Testemonials: What did they say? Why did they say it? What could this mean?
4. Images: Screenshots or Users: What happened? What changed? Why is it relevant?

# IDEA 1: Monkey first

Plan: teach a monkey to recite Shakespeare on a pedestal. Everyone builds the pedestal first — it feels like progress and proves nothing.

Build the monkey. Your riskiest assumption IS the monkey.

# Why Validation matters

# Monkey first — the Google X discipline

X (Google's moonshot factory) attacks the hardest, most uncertain part of every project FIRST.

And it pays BONUSES to teams that kill their own projects on evidence — killing well is a promotion, not a failure (Astro Teller, TED 2016).

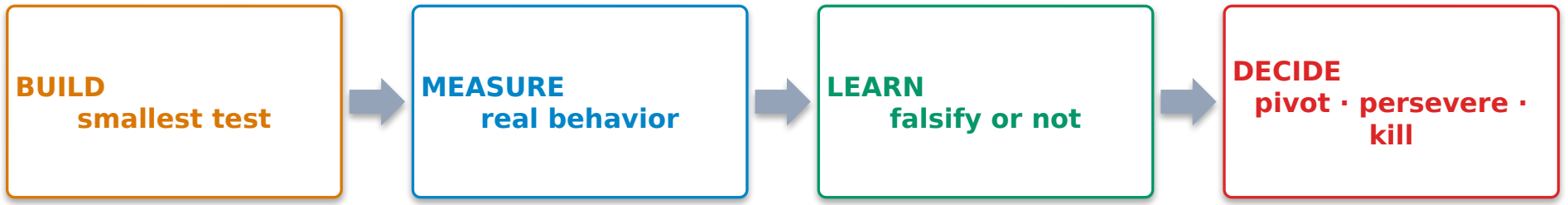
**Your version: name the one assumption that, if false, kills the company. Test THAT this week. €0 tests exist for almost everything — Quibi never ran theirs.**

BUILD TO LEARN

# Every prototype is an experiment.

Stop iterating randomly. Each version of your product is a falsifiable hypothesis — write it down BEFORE you build.

| THE HYPOTHESIS CARD — fill before you build | |
|---|---|
| **WE BELIEVE that** | [customer segment] does [behavior] because [reason] |
| **TO VERIFY, WE WILL** | [the smallest experiment that could possibly tell us] |
| **WE'RE RIGHT IF** | [≥ X % of N people show Y behavior] (specific, measurable, falsifiable) |
| **DECISION** | If TRUE → persevere on [next step]. If FALSE → pivot toward [alternative]. |




Each loop should take days, not weeks. If it takes longer, your experiment is too big.

# IDEA 2: Pre-mortem

It's six months from now and your startup is dead. Write the obituary: what killed it?

Prospective hindsight surfaces the real risks politeness hides — before they're expensive.

THE STAKES

# Why we built it isn't why it lives.

You have a prototype. So did 100% of the startups that died last year.

**42%**

of startups fail because

**there was no market need**

CB Insights, 2023

**70%**

of new products fail

**within their first year**

Harvard Business Review

**10×**

cheaper to learn now

**than after you've scaled**

Steve Blank

**Building is the easy part now. Learning whether what you built deserves to exist is the hard part.**

**"Fall in love with the problem, not the solution." — Uri Levine, founder of Waze**

THE TRAP

# Are you building a feature, or a solution?

Most prototypes solve a problem nobody asked for — but in a way that's just impressive enough to confuse you.

## YOU'RE BUILDING A FEATURE

**Symptoms — does any of this sound familiar?**

- "It would be cool if it also did X."
- Users say "nice" but never come back.
- You're competing with a checkbox in a tool they already pay for.
- The thing you built fits inside someone else's product.
- Nobody would pay for it standalone.

**Reality check: features get acquired or copied. Solutions get adopted.**

## YOU'RE BUILDING A SOLUTION

**Signals — these are what you want to see:**

- Users describe a workflow they had BEFORE you.
- They show you their hack — a spreadsheet, Notion page, WhatsApp group.
- They open your thing without being prompted.
- They get upset when it breaks.
- They send it to a colleague unprompted.

**Reality check: solutions live in someone's workflow. Features live in your demo.**

**Test: if your product disappeared tomorrow, would anyone notice? Would they Google for a replacement?**

PRE-MORTEM

# Imagine you failed.  Now tell me why.

**"It's one year from now.  Our startup is dead.  Write the obituary."**

— Gary Klein, cognitive psychologist · popularized by Daniel Kahneman

## 01

### IMAGINE

**Year one is over. The startup is dead. No survivors.**

Set the scene.  Write the date.  Make it real.

## 02

### BRAINSTORM

**Each founder writes 10+ reasons it died.**

Silent first.  Then share.  Do not censor.  Wild ideas welcome.

## 03

### CLUSTER

**Plot on Likelihood × Impact.**

Top-right corner is where you live.  These are your real risks.

## 04

### PRE-EMPT

**For each top risk, name a test that costs < 1 week.**

If you can't kill the risk cheaply, you've found the assumption to test first.

Why this works:  imagining failure unlocks 30% more candor than asking "what could go wrong".

# IDEA 3: The riskiest assumption

Teams test what's easy to test. Kill decisions need the assumption that's SCARY to test.

Critical × unknown = test now. Critical × known = monitor. Trivial = ignore.

A joint initiative by

THE THREE QUESTIONS

# What you're actually trying to learn.

Validation isn't one thing. It's three different questions — and you need answers to all of them.

## 01

**DESIRABILITY**

### Do they actually want this?

Will someone change their behavior — or pay — to use this?

**Test by**

- Watching what they do
- Asking for commitment
- Counting clicks, not compliments

## 02

**FEASIBILITY**

### Can we actually build this?

Can YOU and your team ship the real version in a meaningful timeframe?

**Test by**

- Strip the prototype to its hardest part
- Do the manual version end-to-end
- Name the one technical bet

## 03

**VIABILITY**

### Does the business work?

Can the unit economics, distribution, and willingness-to-pay sustain a company?

**Test by**

- Ask for money before building
- Size the segment you can reach
- Find the channel where CAC < LTV

**Most founders only test Desirability — and wonder why a working prototype didn't become a working business.**

STEVE BLANK'S MANDATE

# Get out of the building.

> **"There are no facts inside the building, so get the hell outside."**
>
> — Steve Blank, founder of Customer Development

### INSIDE THE BUILDING

What feels like progress, isn't.

- ✗ Adding features your co-founder likes
- ✗ Polishing the landing page copy again
- ✗ Building a pricing page for nobody
- ✗ Re-watching your own demo
- ✗ Refactoring before users
- ✗ Arguing about the logo

### OUTSIDE THE BUILDING

Where the answer actually lives.

- ✓ Watching someone use your thing for the first time
- ✓ Sitting in their canteen, café, office
- ✓ Reading their existing rants in Reddit / reviews
- ✓ Asking what they did last Tuesday — specifically
- ✓ Following them through their workflow
- ✓ Asking for an email, a calendar slot, a euro

**Your job this week: spend more hours WITH users than ON the product. That ratio decides if you ship a real thing.**

THE VALIDATION STACK

# Four experiments.  Pick the cheapest.

Each step costs more but signals more.  Start at the top — climb only when the cheaper test passes.

## 01  SMOKE TEST

**Ad → landing page → fake button**

Tests demand without building.

1–2 days · €50–200

Run a Meta or Google ad pointing to a landing page. Count signups. No product behind it.

## 02  FAKE DOOR

**Button that doesn't work yet**

Tests demand for a feature you haven't built.

1 hour · €0

Add the button. When clicked: "Coming soon — leave email." Measure click-through, not opinions.

## 03  WIZARD OF OZ

**Real frontend, human backend**

Tests value — you fake the automation.

1–2 weeks · your time

User uses the product. You do the work manually behind the scenes. They never know.

## 04  CONCIERGE MVP

**You ARE the product**

Tests if anyone wants the outcome at all.

2–4 weeks · your time

Deliver the value manually for 10 customers. No product. Learn what they actually need.

**Heuristic:  the cheaper the test that kills your idea, the better.**

DATA FAST

# Your users have been ranting for years.

Before you run a single interview, mine the data that already exists.  It's free, asynchronous, and unfiltered.

## REDDIT & FORUMS

**Specific subreddit · Top of Year**

- Search:  "why does X suck"  ·  "alternative to Y"
- Open threads with > 50 upvotes — real, repeated pain
- Copy direct quotes — your headline copy in waiting
- Tools:  reddit search  ·  GummySearch

## APP REVIEWS & G2

**1- and 2-star reviews of incumbents**

- Find your competitor on G2 / Capterra / App Store
- Filter to 1–2 stars — these are your future users
- Cluster the complaints — biggest cluster is the gap
- Tools:  AppFollow  ·  G2 scraper

## COMMUNITY CHANNELS

**Slack · Discord · Luma · Meetup**

- Find 3 channels where your customer hangs out
- Lurk a week — what do they ask for help with?
- Search the channel for problem keywords
- Tools:  Slack search  ·  Discord  ·  Luma

## SUPPORT & SEARCH

**Tickets + Google autocomplete**

- Read 50 support tickets (even from a friendly user)
- Google autocomplete:  "how to ___"
- Answer The Public — what people actually search
- Tools:  Google Trends  ·  Answer The Public

**Goal:  20 verbatim quotes from real customers before tomorrow's stand-up.**

INTO THE FLOW

# Get into the application — fast.

Interviews are signal-poor.  Watching them work for 30 minutes tells you more than three calls.  Embed yourself in their workflow.

## WATCH

### Shadow for 30 min.

Cost:  1 coffee

**Setup**

Sit next to them while they do the workflow.

**Capture**

- Every app / tab they switch to
- Every curse, sigh, copy-paste
- Time each step takes
- The workaround they already built

## WORK ALONGSIDE

### Pair for half a day.

Cost:  4h + free pizza

**Setup**

Pair on a real task this week.  They drive — you take notes.

**Capture**

- Where they invent their own process
- Which step nobody documents
- What they'd never put in a survey
- Who else they coordinate with

## CONCIERGE

### Be the product, 10 users.

Cost:  1–2 weeks

**Setup**

Deliver the value manually for 10 customers.  No software.

**Capture**

- The 20% that drives 80% of value
- What they'll PAY (even €1) for
- Which edge cases break the model
- Whether they refer the next one

**30 min shadowing > 3 hours interviewing.  Half a day pairing > a week of surveys.**

# IDEA 4: Go · Pivot · Kill

The criteria were written before the data (M04's threshold, every week's kill line). Now we honor them.

A kill on evidence is a scientific win — and in this course, an A-grade path.

THE DECISION

# Pivot, persevere, or kill?

Eric Ries' Lean Startup question: is our engine of growth gaining momentum? Answer with data, not feelings.

## ✓ PERSEVERE

**Double down. Same direction.**

Signals you should keep going:

- Repeat usage is climbing week-over-week
- Users complain when it breaks
- Unprompted referrals (someone sent you a friend)
- Someone paid — even €1 — without you pushing
- You can name 3 testimonials that aren't your mum

## ↻ PIVOT

**Core insight valid. Direction wrong.**

Signals you should change one variable:

- The PROBLEM is real, but YOUR solution is meh
- One feature is loved, the rest is ignored
- You're attracting users you didn't expect
- Willingness to pay sits with a different segment
- The same conversation: "I love it for X, but..."

## ✗ KILL

**No engine. Move on.**

Signals to stop investing:

- No commitment after 5+ user tests
- Free users churn within a week
- You can't articulate who this is for
- You've pivoted 3+ times — the floor keeps moving
- Founders are losing energy, not gaining it

**Decide on a TIMEBOX. "We'll know by Friday." Not "someday". Not "when it feels right".**

# The GPK scorecard — 9 questions, scored on artifacts

Evidence for the PROBLEM (3 questions) · evidence for the SOLUTION (3) · evidence you can WIN (3).

Each scored 0–2 from your Toolkit artifacts — interviews, thresholds, prototype reactions. Not vibes.

**Under 9/18: kill zone · 9–13: pivot zone · 14+: go. The full sheet is framework 03 (GPK Decision Framework).**

# Your verdict today is PROVISIONAL

Announce it publicly. Write the kill line next to it. Then run the monkey-first test this week.

**The verdict gets CONFIRMED at Module 08 check-in — after the test ran, not before.**

Killing? The Restart Ramp is in your homework: Kill Ritual → 48h re-ideation from your existing artifacts → concierge offer ready by next week. Demo Day is fully reachable from here.

# What the evidence says

Pre-mortems measurably improve risk identification — prospective hindsight ~30% better at naming causes (Klein 2007; Mitchell, Russo & Pennington 1989).

The enemy has a name: escalation of commitment (Staw 1976). Quibi is today's exhibit.

Affordable loss beats expected-value dreams at this stage (Sarasvathy 2001) — and yes, the lean method has serious critiques too (Felin et al. 2020). Thresholds, not theater.

# END RECAP — today in four lines

1 · Build the monkey, not the pedestal

2 · Write the obituary before the funeral — pre-mortem

3 · Test what's scary, not what's easy

4 · GPK on pre-committed criteria; provisional today, confirmed next week

**A kill with evidence beats a zombie with a pitch deck. Every time.**

# Workshop: Kill Your Darlings (90 min)

Agenda lives in M07_Workshop_Kill-Your-Darlings.md — pre-mortem, kill criteria, GPK scoring, peer tribunal, public (provisional) decision.

**Must produce: GPK scorecard + your announced provisional verdict + the kill line for this week's test.**

Kill criteria: your tribunal defense used the word 'potential' more than the word 'evidence'.

# Wrapup & Checkout

# APPENDIX — original slides (instructor's cut candidates)

**Everything below stayed in the deck — moved out of the flow, not deleted. Mark KEEP (returns to flow) or KILL. Only Basti deletes.**

## Check-In:

# How many users did you talk to?

Now you might want to make use of your team!

7 user interaction

1.400 impressions

10% WoW user growth

## Don‘t struggle alone

Now you might want to make use of your team!

Interviews

Engagement

Product Building

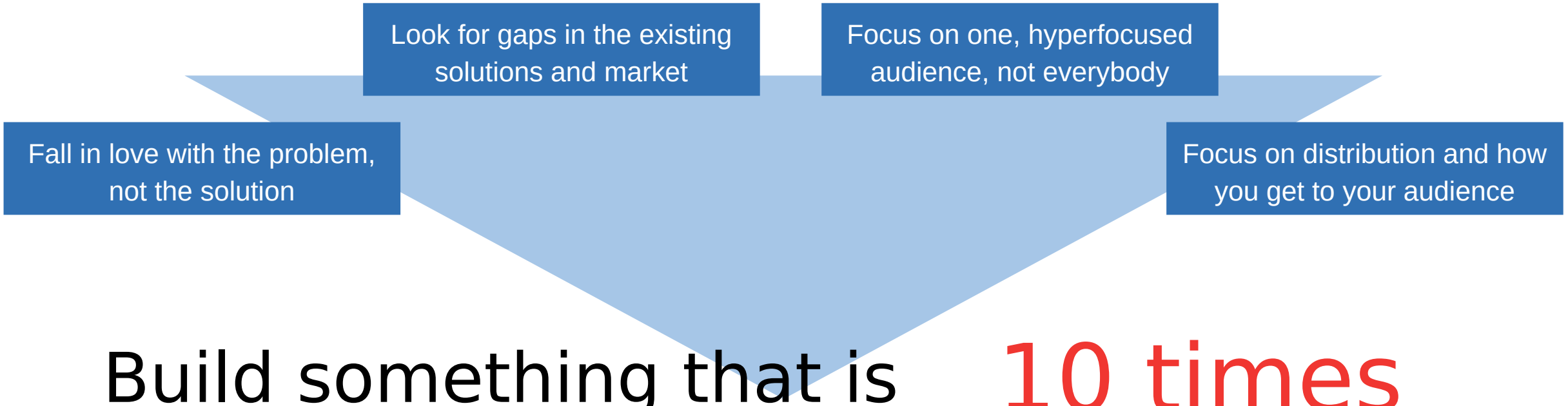
Now you might want to make use of your team!

P. Understanding

P. Validation

S. Product-Market-Fit

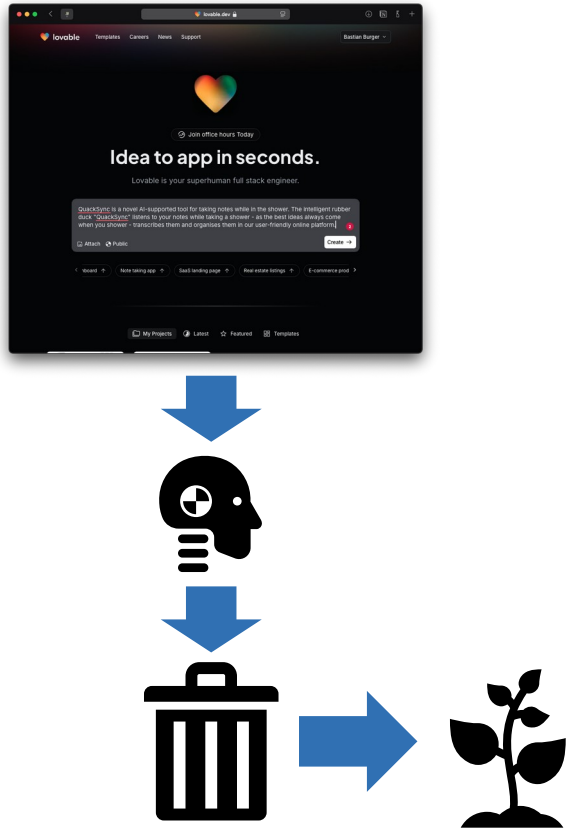
# Core principles for problems and ideas




Build something that is 10 times better than what your users have now

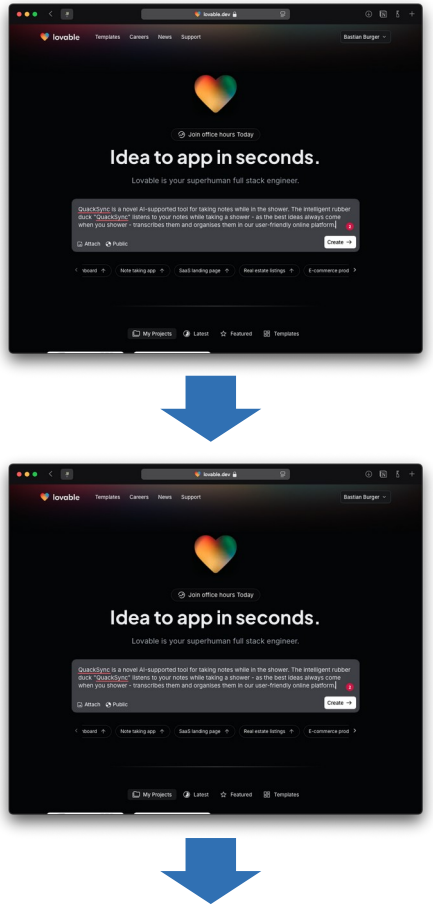
# Now, we are building to get users

Build to find a seed for our solution:



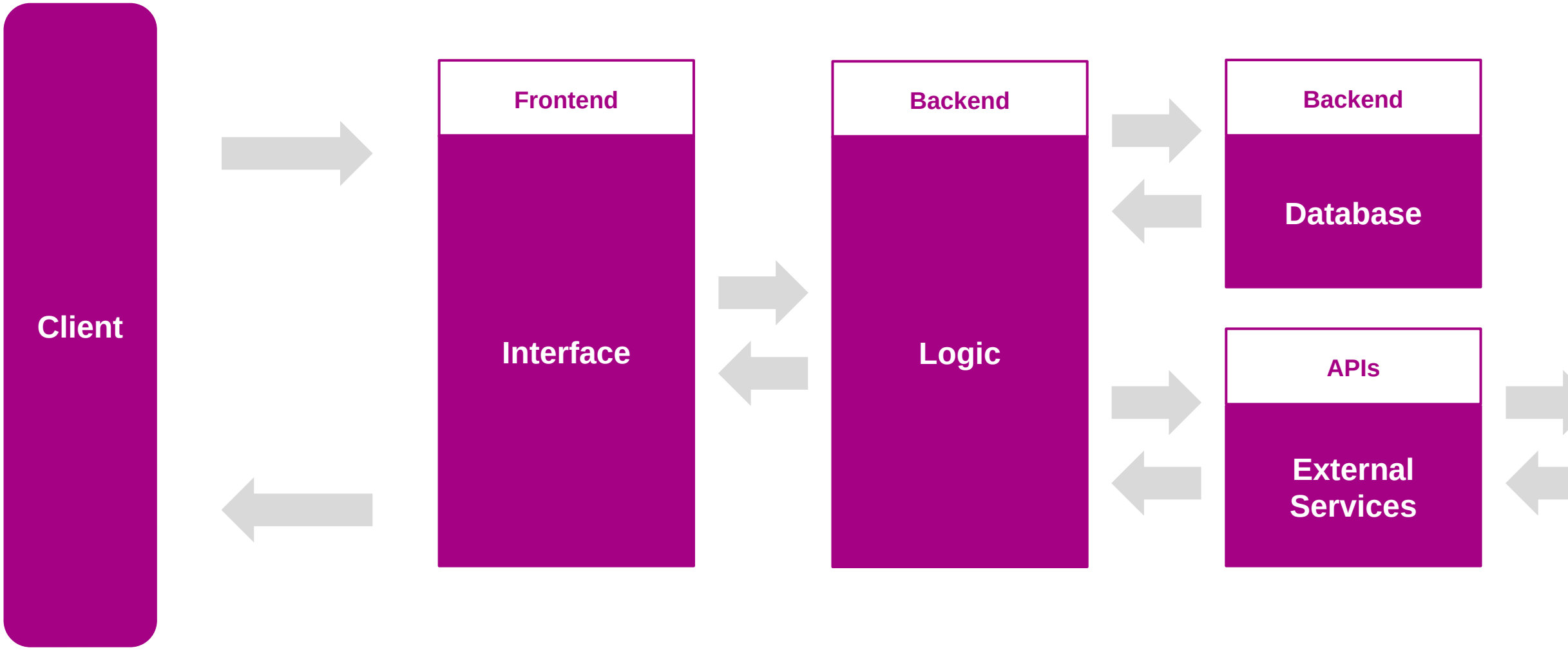

(Divergent thinking, going broad)

Build to improve on the solution:




(Covergent thinking, going narrow)

# Every application ever



# Key takeaway: Don‘t confuse your product with your solution

**Product:**
New kind of aircraft



Nach dem Verkauf der Patente bleibt nichts mehr übrig von Lilium. © *Lilium*

## War’s das jetzt mit Lilium?

Welchen

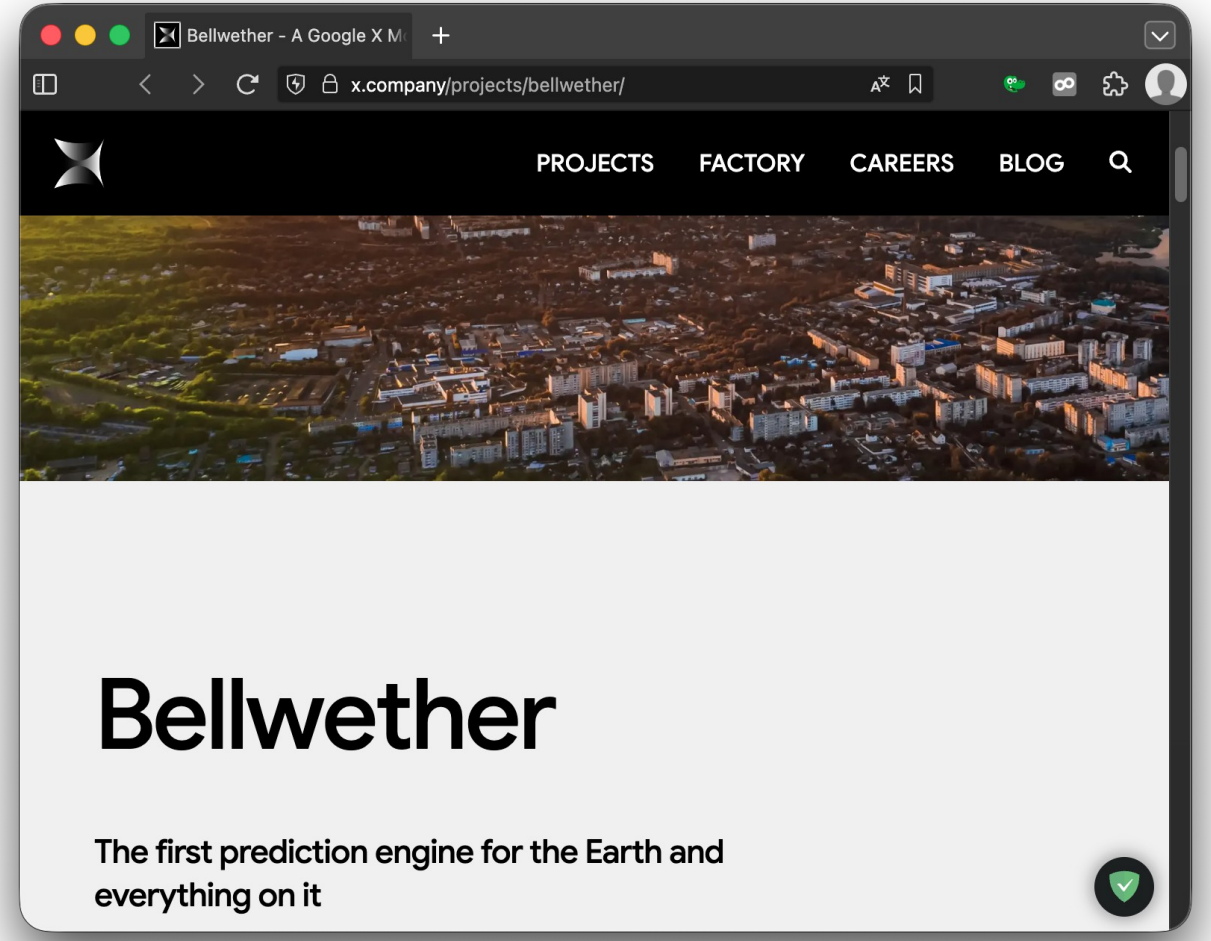
Vom Hoffnungsträger zum Mahnmal: Das einstige Aushängeschild der deutschen Luftfahrtinnovation, Lilium, ist Geschichte. Nach dem Verkauf seiner Patente an den US-Konkurrenten Archer Aviation für rund 18 Millionen

**Solution:**
Getting through urban traffic without interruptions

**The market will alway prefer the least risky/*innovative* solution:**
Was this the right technology to deliver something as mondane as their problem?

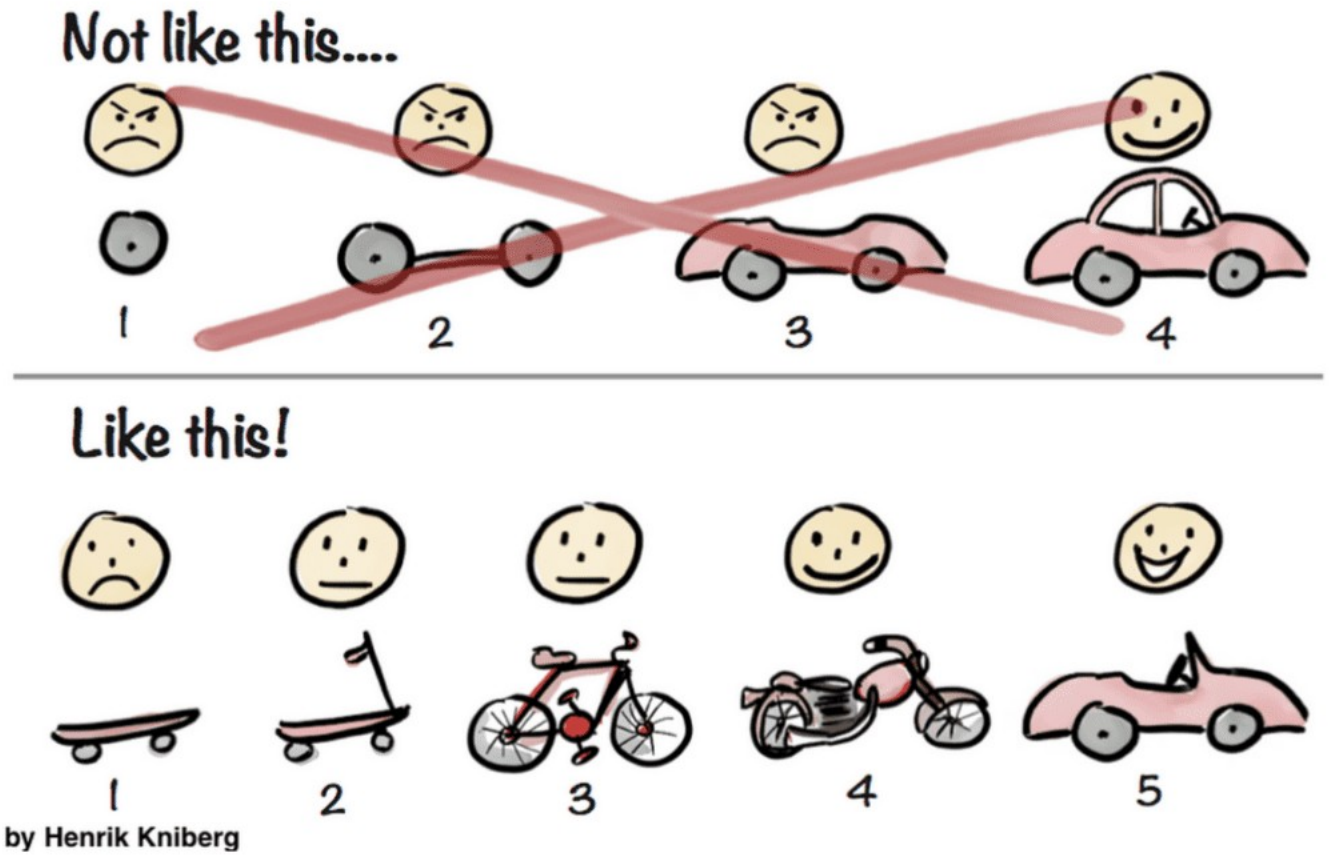
# Getting Data to work on

# Don‘t wait for the data to come to you



# Why work with real data

I want to build a self-driving car



# Why work with real data

I‘d like to have access to all your patients files to see if I can store them more effectively

**Yeah, how about no?**



# Why work with real data

I‘d like to have access to your patient files in the xyz format because I can provide data more efficiently for the sowhat-procedure.
I tested it with my own data, then a doctor in training, then a private physician.



**Sounds legit!**

The more specific
you are, the more support
you will get.

You build specificity
through trial & error

# Data repositories you can use

## Public Data:

WFP World Food Programme

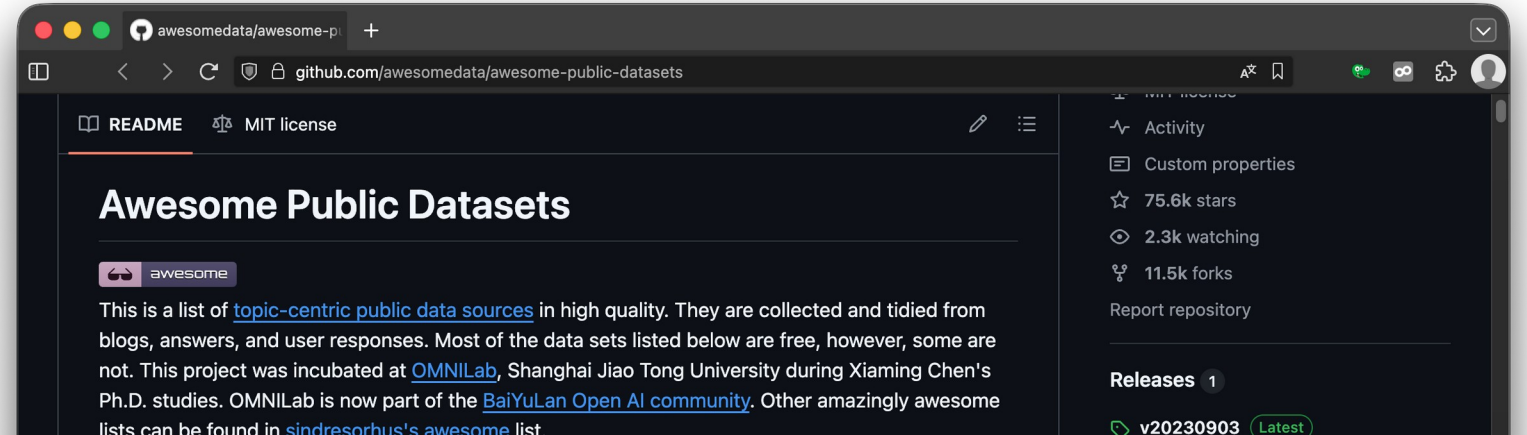
CDC U.S. CENTERS FOR DISEASE CONTROL AND PREVENTION

eurostat

## Private Data:

kaggle

GitHub



# Need more closed data

## Data Collection:

amazon mechanical turk

QUADRANT an appen company

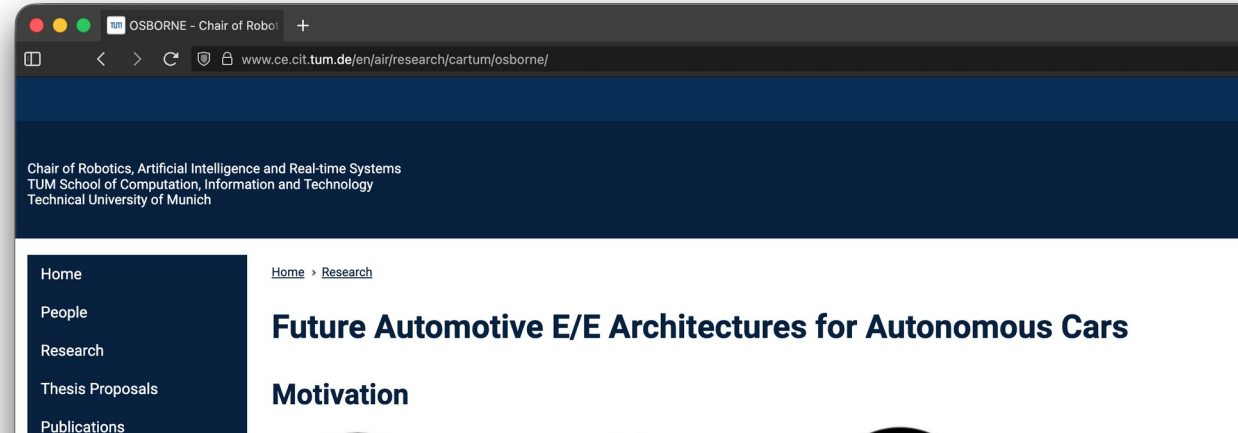
Bundesagentur für Arbeit bringt weiter.

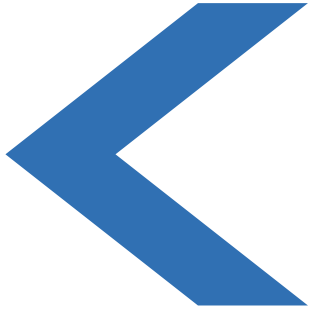
## Company Data:

kaggle

Technische Universität München

PLUGANDPLAY



Great Dummy Data  Bad Real Data

# Offload processing costs

Pick a provider,
don‘t overthink









…and many other, including
European Cloud providers…

Tier 1:
~1.000€

Tier 2:
~10.000€

Tier 3:
~100.000€



They want to see you progress and use the credits

# If you know what you are doing, you will get funding!

**RCP**

(Random Cloud Platform)

Tier 1:
~1.000€



Proof, the idea works.

Tier 2:
~10.000€

Proof, you can do it at scale.

Tier 3:
~100.000€

Proof, you are the best.

# OpenAI is also just boiling with water

GPT-1 (2018)

## Base Concept

ORGANIZATION CONTEXT

OpenAI was a pure non-profit research lab battling deep skepticism against unsupervised generative models.

BUSINESS/SCIENTIFIC PAIN

Traditional NLP required developers to build, label, and train unique custom models for each distinct task.

PRIMARY METRIC GOAL

Prove "pre-train once, fine-tune anywhere" is technically viable.

GPT-2 (2019)

## Scale Validation

ORGANIZATION CONTEXT

Transitioning to a "capped-profit" entity to aggressively secure capital for massive compute infrastructure.

BUSINESS/SCIENTIFIC PAIN

Even fine-tuning required target data. Startups and labs lacked labeled datasets to train specific domains.

PRIMARY METRIC GOAL

Prove zero-shot generalization scales predictably with raw model size.

GPT-3/3.5 (2020-22)

## Commercial Shift

ORGANIZATION CONTEXT

Formed strategic alliance with Microsoft. Monetization through closed developer APIs.

BUSINESS/SCIENTIFIC PAIN

Raw outputs were erratic and unsafe for businesses. Highly unaligned responses caused brand risk.

PRIMARY METRIC GOAL

Integrate RLHF (alignment) to build robust, human-friendly conversational interfaces.

GPT-4 (2023)

## Enterprise Power

ORGANIZATION CONTEXT

Operating as a dominant market powerhouse, optimizing software-copilot integrations globally.

BUSINESS/SCIENTIFIC PAIN

Hallucinations, weak logic, and text-only constraints limited usage in high-risk markets (law, finance, healthcare).

PRIMARY METRIC GOAL

Achieve human-level exam logic and robust multimodal (text/visual) ingestion.

# This could have been you!

| Model | Target Audience & Intent | Core Business Constraint Solved | Training Ingestion Shift |
|---|---|---|---|
| GPT-1 | **Academic Researchers**<br>Validate the transformers architecture. | High cost and extreme delays in collecting custom human-labeled data for single tasks. | **BookCorpus**<br>Focused on continuous clean narrative strings. |
| GPT-2 | **AI Pioneers & Competitors**<br>Establish the law of scaling compute. | The "Cold-Start" developer hurdle—needing domain-expert datasets just to launch a basic tool. | **WebText (Reddit Outbound)**<br>Transition to organic, curated web content. |
| GPT-3 / 3.5 | **Startups & SaaS Devs**<br>Monetize the API and prompt workflows. | User friction with formatting. Introduced zero-shot prompting to replace programming. | **Common Crawl**<br>Massive general web dump + Human RLHF tuning. |
| GPT-4 | **Fortune 500 Enterprises**<br>Incorporate deep agentic reasoning. | Unreliability, rigid formatting errors, and inability to read physical/visual asset data. | **Undisclosed Multimodal**<br>Merged high-res imagery with rich code text. |

# Getting Use Cases

# Formulate & Prioritize Hypotheses

## Goal

Create clear, measurable predictions based on key assumptions that help iteratively test our understanding of problems/ needs

## How

- Articulate your hypotheses about various aspects, such as the customer segment, problem-solution fit, value proposition
- Make them specific, testable, actionable
- Prioritize by considering potential impact, level of uncertainty, and feasibility/ease



# Formulate Hypotheses

**Definde Assumption:**

à Founders have difficulties structuring their internal processes.

à Founders would benefit from a practical course that teaches them how to use Notion to set up internal structures.

→ Founders have limited time, which restricts their ability to focus on organizing and structuring their teams effectively. They require solutions that are efficient and time-saving to help them manage team organization and structure.

*Use ChatGPT to convert assumptions into hypotheses:*
*"Convert the following assumptions about my idea into testable hypotheses"*

→ **Hypothesis:** Founders who participate in a survey or interview will report that they face significant challenges in managing multiple tasks and making decisions.

→ **Hypothesis:** Founders who complete a practical course on using Notion for internal structures will report an improvement in their ability to manage tasks and decisions effectively.

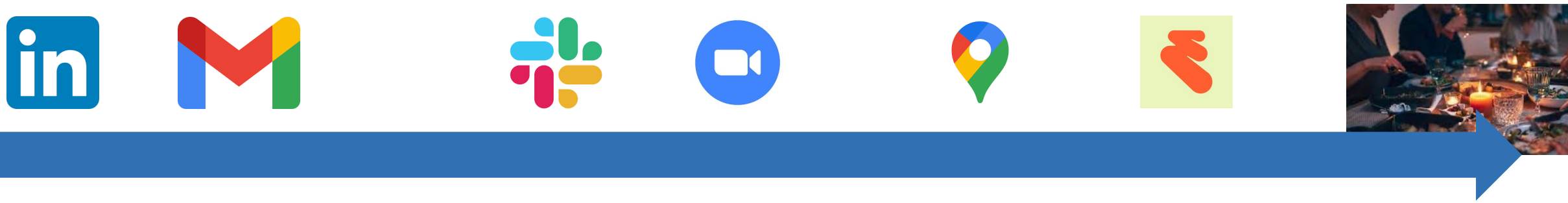
→ **Hypothesis:** Founders will prefer and adopt solutions that are marketed as efficient and time-saving for managing team organization and structure.

# Let‘s reach out!

**Please check before sending out!**

**Remember Conversion:**
**1 High Quality Lead**
**is worth about**
**10-50 Low Quality Leads**

# Find a place for personal connections



Unpersonal & Annoying

Personal & Pleasant

# Use brand association



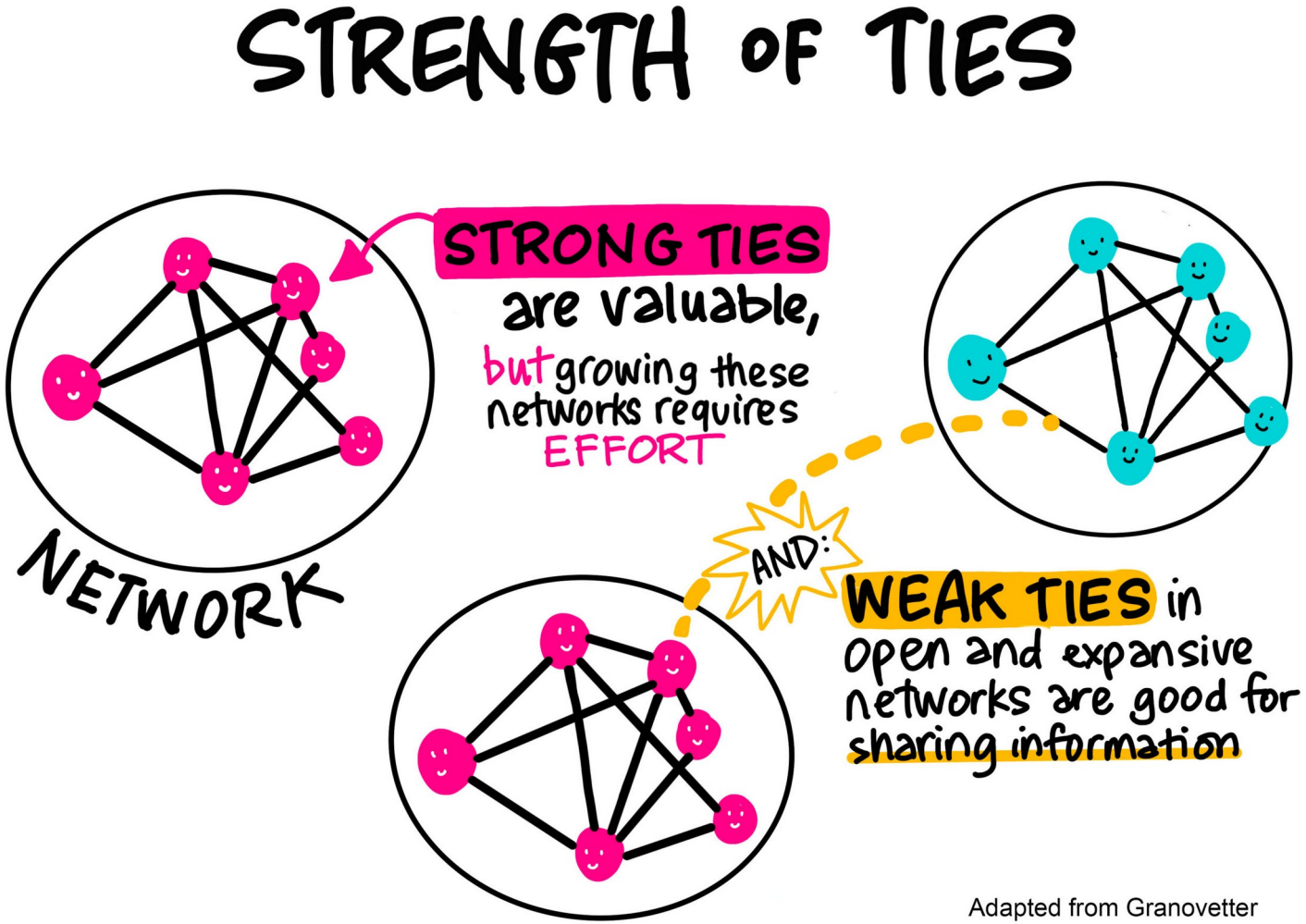
I‘m the CEO of startup2000.io and
Would like to discuss AI applications in your company

I‘m a PhD candidate at TUM and
Would like to discuss AI applications in your company

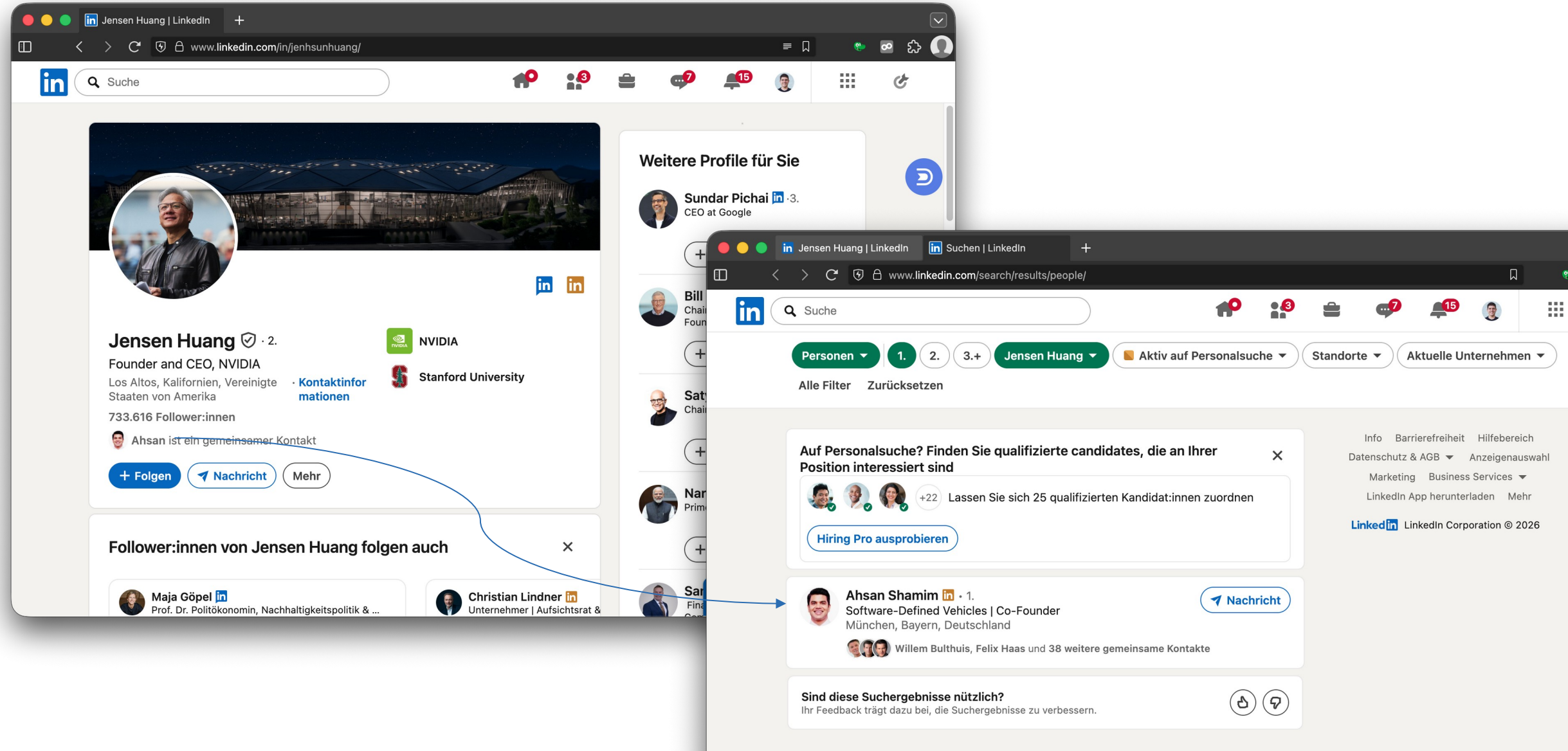
- Use Educational Email
- Namedrop or affiliate your professor
- Add your affiliation into your signature

*„A google.com email opens almost any door for you.“*
– head of Google X Rapid Valuation Department

# Use the power of weak ties



# Find the best ties to ask for intros (ideally 2nd degree)



# Making Meaningful Connections

# Finding Common Interests

**Explanation:** The goal of this level is to practice finding common ground with others by exploring beyond surface-level conversations.

**Motivation:** Finding shared interests helps form a strong basis for relationships and makes people feel more connected and understood.

# Making a good first impression (Leil Lowndes)

- Don‘t touch your face or fidget around
- Gift them your attention and a smile
- Imagine new people as „old friends“
- Smalltalk can be the leaway to more meaningful topics
- Cliches < Stating Facts < „We Statements“
- Never give a „Naked Answer“
- Echo the Emo
- Track what you want to remember about the other person
- Lead by asking questions

- “So what is your favourite Deep Purple album?“ – „Why?“

# Learn the names

**Explanation:** The goal of this level is to get into the habit of remembering and recalling the name of the person you are interacting with.

**Motivation:** A person‘s name is one of the strongest words to that person. You will have a very much simpler time associating a person when you know their name rather than only „you“.

# Making a good first impression (Leil Lowndes)

- Don‘t touch your face or fidget around
- Gift them your attention and a smile
- Imagine new people as „old friends“
- Smalltalk can be the leaway to more meaningful topics
- Cliches < Stating Facts < „We Statements“
- Never give a „Naked Answer“
- Echo the Emo
- Track what you want to remember about the other person
- Lead by asking questions

- „Hey Basti, how is your cat Vio doing? Is she feeling more at home with your son Noel?

# Making a Pleasant Entry (Dale Carnegy)

1. Show genuine Interest in the other person, find something interesting
2. A smile goes a long way
3. People love hearing their own names
4. **Never come empty handed**
5. Always leave the door open (No arguments, no calling out, admiting mistakes)

Dale Carnegy: How to Win Friends and Influence People (https://opac.ub.tum.de/TouchPoint/singleHit.do?methodToCall=showHit&curPos=6&identifier=2_SOLR_SERVER_2014139736)

# Seek first to understand, then to be understood (Stephen Covey)

## Most People

Listen with the intend to reply

Autobiographical Listening:

- Evaluating “I don‘t think that‘s a good idea!
- Probing „Why don‘t you do something different“
- Advising „Here is what you need to do“
- Interpreting „I know exactly how you feel“

Well intended but actually not very helpful

## Effective Communicators

Listen with the intend to understand

Empathetic Listening:

- Mimic
- Rephrase
- Reflect

Just build mutual understanding

Stephen R. Covey: The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People (https://opac.ub.tum.de/TouchPoint/singleHit.do?methodToCall=showHit&curPos=1&identifier=2_SOLR_SERVER_1089017770)

# And Always: Tell your Story

**Explanation:** Thus far, we have only been working on our listening skills, as these make a good communicator and are the precondition to meaningful connections. Now, we want to help you get your word out.

**Motivation:** Connecting over a story is the oldest form of human interaction.

# Workshop: Try your solution in the open

# Workshop Objectives

YOUR GOAL

**Find real data to throw at your solution**

**By the end, you will have:**

- ✓ Data that you can work with to learn of your solution works
- ✓ 3 specific pilots
- ✓ Week 1 action plan with targets

## Workshop Structure

**20 min** **Exercise 1: Find data sources**
Define what data you need and find it

**20 min** **Exercise 2: Find Real World Applications**
Identify where your customers are & how to reach them

**20 min** **Exercise 3: Build Your Action Plan**
Download data & reach out

**20 min** **Share & Feedback**
Present your plan to peers & iterate

THE TRAP

# Are you building a feature, or a solution?

Most prototypes solve a problem nobody asked for — but in a way that's just impressive enough to confuse you.

## YOU'RE BUILDING A FEATURE

**Symptoms — does any of this sound familiar?**

- "It would be cool if it also did X."
- Users say "nice" but never come back.
- You're competing with a checkbox in a tool they already pay for.
- The thing you built fits inside someone else's product.
- Nobody would pay for it standalone.

**Reality check: features get acquired or copied. Solutions get adopted.**

## YOU'RE BUILDING A SOLUTION

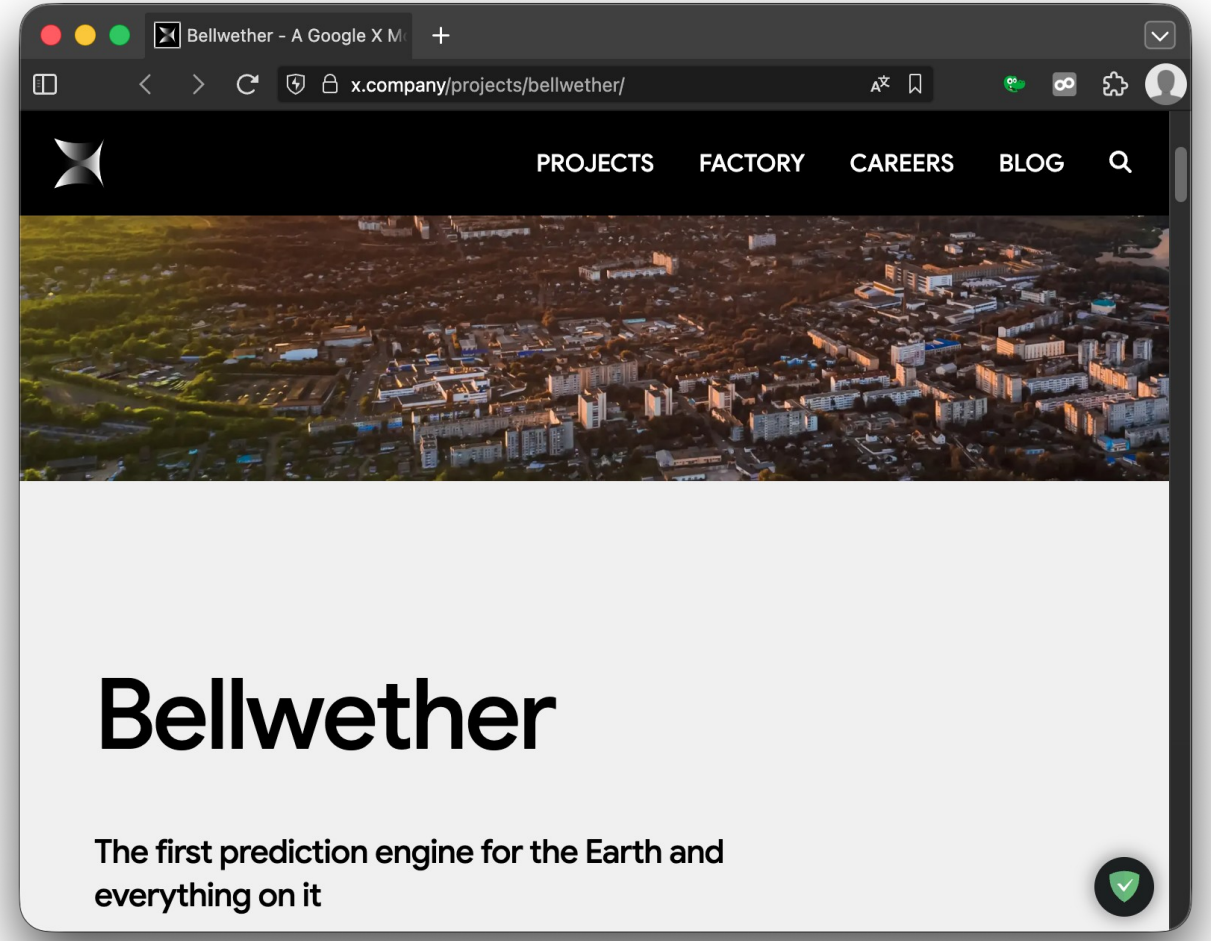
**Signals — these are what you want to see:**

- Users describe a workflow they had BEFORE you.
- They show you their hack — a spreadsheet, Notion page, WhatsApp group.
- They open your thing without being prompted.
- They get upset when it breaks.
- They send it to a colleague unprompted.

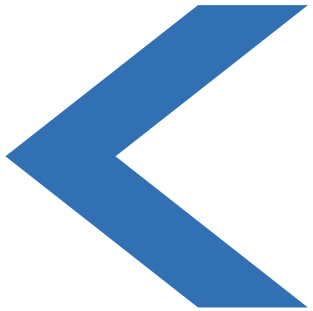
**Reality check: solutions live in someone's workflow. Features live in your demo.**

**Test: if your product disappeared tomorrow, would anyone notice? Would they Google for a replacement?**

# Don‘t wait for the data to come to you



The more specific
you are, the more support
you will get.

Great Dummy Data  Bad Real Data

# If you know what you are doing, you will get funding!

**RCP**

(Random Cloud Platform)

Tier 1:
~1.000€



Proof, the idea works.

Tier 2:
~10.000€

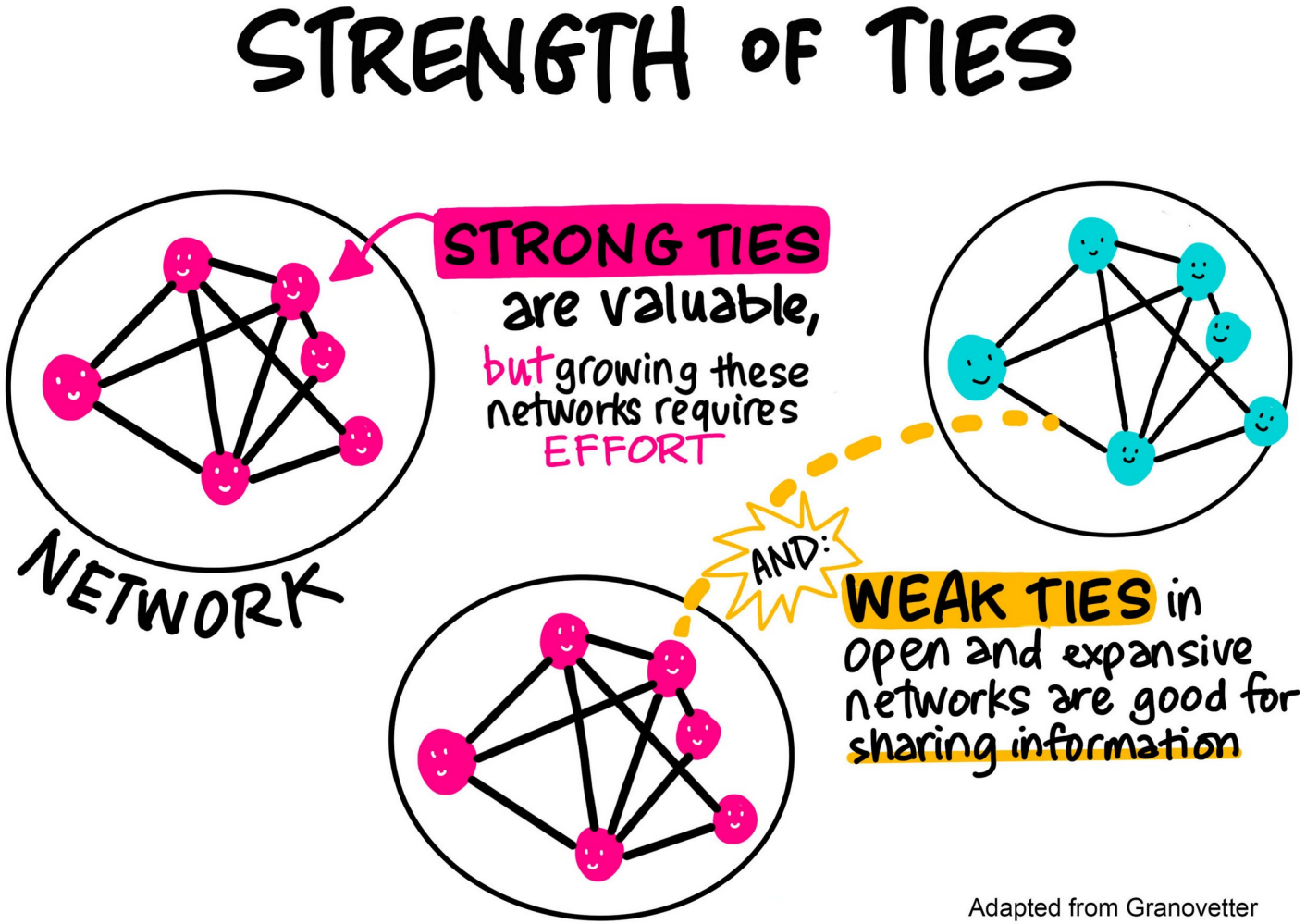
Proof, you can do it at scale.

Tier 3:
~100.000€

amazon mechanical turk

Proof, you are the best.

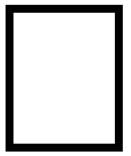
# Use the power of weak ties



# Reflection 1: The Content – What could you apply

What could you apply?

What gave you a hard time?



# Reflection 2: The Process – Man vs. Machine

Where did AI actually help you?

Where was your genius needed?

What are your best hacks to share?

# Reflection 3: The Results – Rose, Thorn, Bud

What was the breakthrough today?

What was the hardest part today?

What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?

Everything you do should work from real data. Every improvement is driven from reality, not from possiblity.